



HORIZON

ZERO DAWN™

CARAVAN

SANDWITCH

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For the Playing Futures Conference, Copenhagen, 20-05-2026

**Growing up in the post-apocalypse.
Coming-of-age imaginaries of ecology
and climate crisis in Horizon Zero
Dawn and Caravan Sandwich.**



Universitat
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Barcelona



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-Why

-Coming-of-age
narratives as a
(post)capitalist device

-Imaginaries of ecology
and environment

-Play and hack

Why

‘Why is it important that we understand how videogames use coming-of-age narratives in playable ecofictions?’

‘Does this kind of analysis make sense in exploring the future of play in climate and energy futures (plural)?’

‘What can this method of analysis actually bring forth, and is that of importance to understand how play could, would, or will be situated in potential futures?’

Coming-of-age narratives as a capitalist device

Coming-of-age

Franco Moretti (1987),
Anna Telnes Iversen
(2010), Stella Bolaki,
(2011), Sarah Graham
(2019)

Media studies, cultural studies, sociocultural imaginaries and ludonarrative imaginaries

Cornelius Castoriadis
(1975, ed. 2013), Stuart
Hall (1996), Charles
Taylor (2004), Òliver
Pérez-Latorre (2023)

Participatory and convergence culture

Henry Jenkins (2006),
Marshall McLuhan
and Bruce R. Powers
(1989)

Coming-of-age in videogames

Stepahnie Harkin (2021,
2025), Liting Kway and
Alex Mitchell (2018),
Lisanne Meinen (2024)

Coming-of-age narratives as a (post)capitalist device

It helps us to understand what priorities, choices and dilemmas arise in the present, how they differ from the past, and how they might evolve in the future.



Imaginaries of ecology and environment

Or, better, the lack of imaginaries.

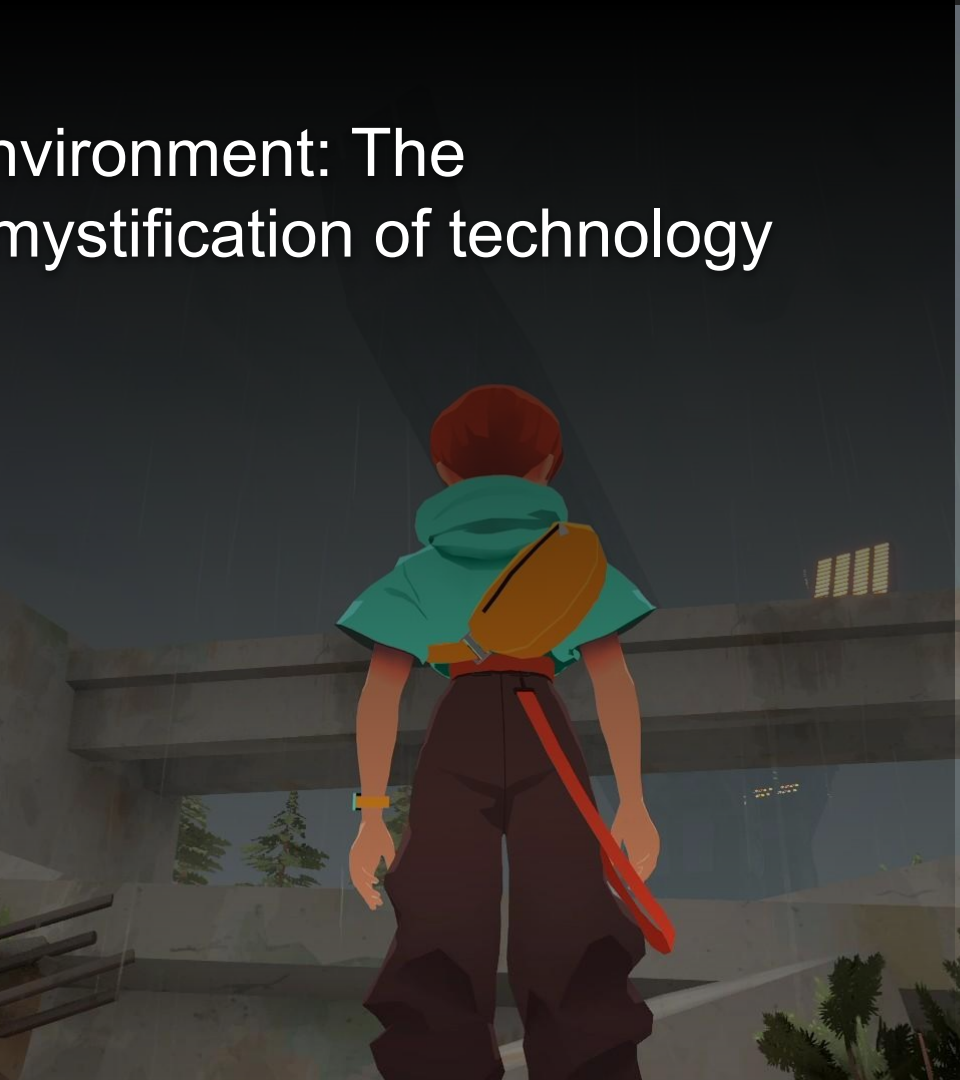
Rost: The wilds can be dangerous, Aloy. You will need to stay close and do as I say.



Imaginaries of ecology and environment: The remystification of nature and mystification of technology and AI



Rost: All machines are dangerous, Aloy. Their power must be respected. But I will be beside you.



Imaginaries of ecology and environment: The remystification of nature and mystification of technology and AI



Rost: All machines are dangerous, Aloy. Their power must be respected.

Imaginaries of ecology and environment: Robots and machines, and how to take them apart. The reappropriation of technology



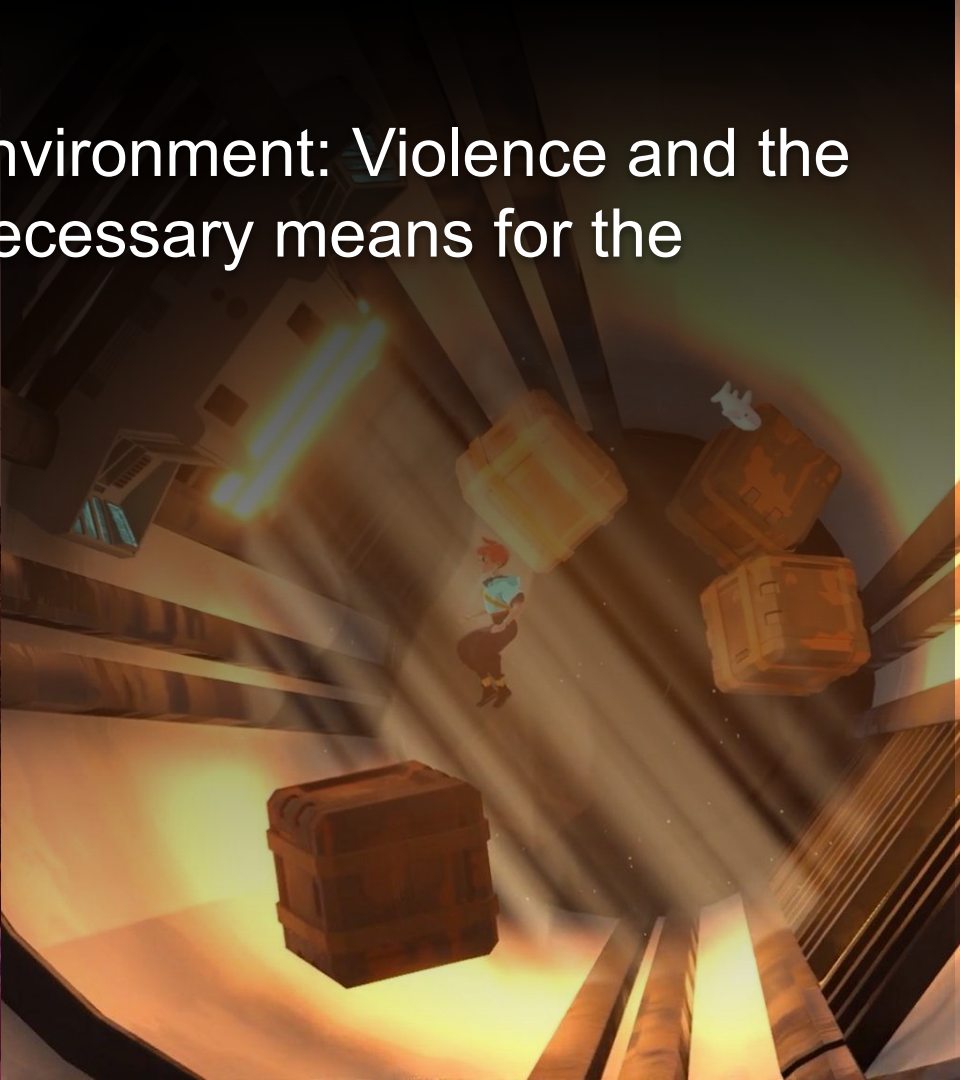
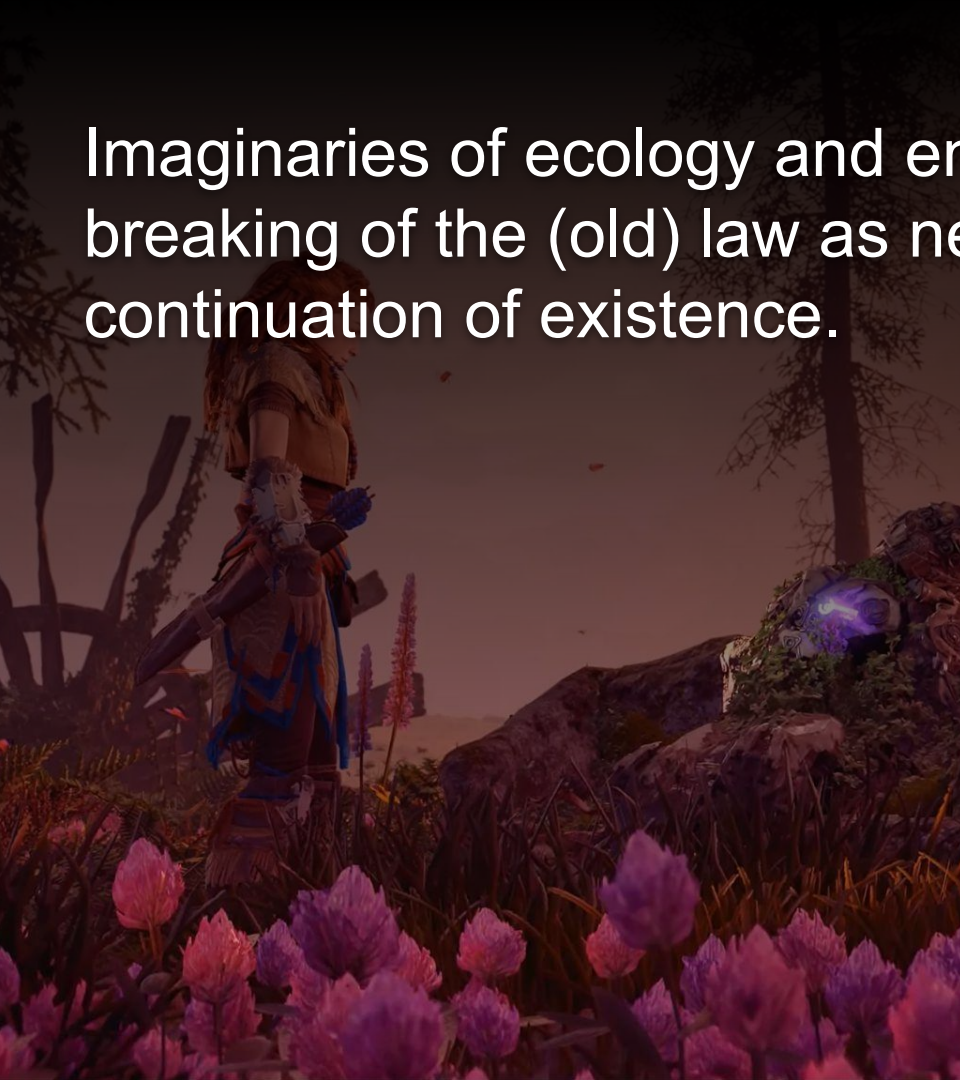
Aloy: I need to know how that machine took possession of those Striders.



Imaginaries of ecology and environment: Youth cannot shape the future... alone



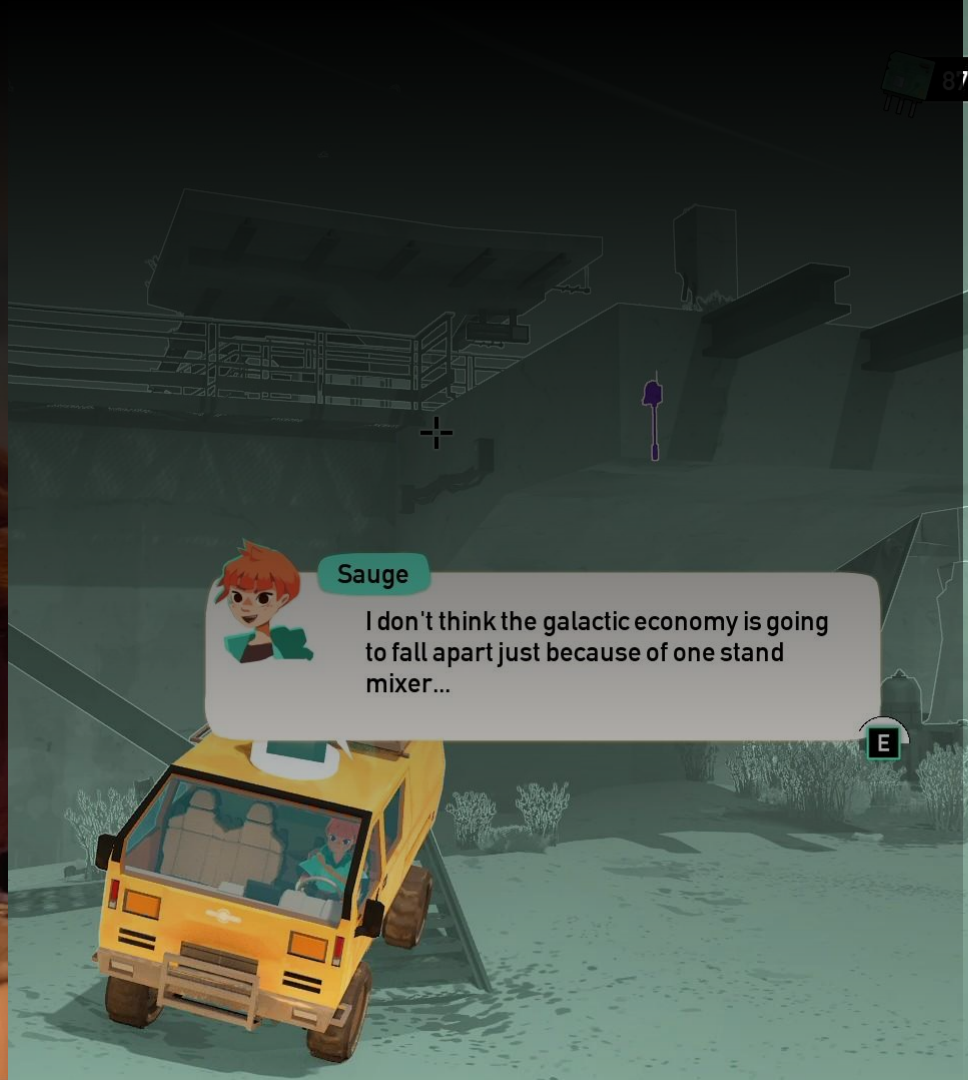
Imaginaries of ecology and environment: Violence and the breaking of the (old) law as necessary means for the continuation of existence.



Play and hack



Aloy: Looks like it'll hold. I just need to test it.



Sauge

I don't think the galactic economy is going to fall apart just because of one stand mixer...

E

Conclusion: interplay between agency and community



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Elisabet Sobeck: Right. Yeah... so, like I was saying,

Thank you very much
for you attention :)

